

Final creative surge

After the relatively lean decades of the 1920s and 1930s, Strauss experienced a new surge of creative energy. Having begun with *Capriccio*, his renewed flourishing continued with the second horn concerto, two wind sonatinas, and a delectable oboe concerto. All these works nostalgically refract the spirit of Mozart through a Straussian harmonic prism. Quoting the funeral march of Beethoven's "Eroica" Symphony, the elegiac *Metamorphosen* is Strauss's lament for the physical and cultural devastation of Germany. His swan song, the *Vier letzte Lieder* (Four Last Songs, 1948), is at once a consummation of his lifelong love affair with the soprano voice and a profound valediction, embracing sleep and oblivion serenely and without sentimentality. Here is the whole German Romantic tradition in its glorious death agony.

Having used his influence to protect his Jewish daughter-in-law and grandsons from the Nazis (see [box](#)), Strauss went into exile in Switzerland after the war. He was cleared by the denazification tribunal in 1948, and, already ailing, returned to Germany the following year. He died at Garmisch on September 8, 1949.

Fame and modesty

For all his fame, Strauss never lost the aura of a down-to-earth Bavarian, at his happiest sharing a game of skat (a card game) with friends. Yet the outward nonchalance was deceptive. A meticulous professional, Strauss once remarked wryly: "I may not be a first-rate composer, but I am a first-rate second-rate